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Moving metaphors we live by: water and flow in the social sciences and around hydroelectric dams in Kyrgyzstan

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Based on anthropological fieldwork between 2006 and 2008, this article compares how people in the Toktogul region of Kyrgyzstan understand and interact with water in three highly significant places: mountain pastures (*jailoo*s), the Toktogul hydroelectric dam that controls the flow of the Naryn and sacred sites (*mazar*s). Sidelining the vast standing waters of Toktogul Reservoir, valley residents instead highlight the positive qualities of flowing water at *mazar*s, pastures and the working dam. Contrasting how metaphors of running water are put to use conceptually by Toktogul residents and social scientists opens up a critique of current academic and policy-oriented descriptions of the world as 'flow'. Attention to a particular kind of movement (flowing water) highlights some of the silent assumptions in current depictions of a mobile world 'in flux'.

Keywords: movement; flow; water; Kyrgyzstan; dams; sacred sites; pastures

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Introduction: moving water in practice and language

Toktogul Dam, central Kyrgyzstan, 11 June 2008. Our car moves through the clammy darkness for a long time. My companion, Bekmurat, worked on building this tunnel in the 1960s, until his early retirement after 15 years of dangerous labour in the dark. Now three kilometres of tunnel lie behind us, along with the barracks of the security services and soldiers who guard this place. We drive on and emerge suddenly into the blinding noonday sun, surrounded by hot walls of rock, on the bridge of an enormous dam. Standing here, the dam looks like a huge lump of concrete poured between vertical cliffs. Upriver, the water stretches still and turquoise; downstream, water churns up from inside the concrete wall. Large electricity pylons mount the rocks, marching away to supply Kyrgyzstan with most of its electricity. There is nothing here but rock, water and the concrete plug we stand on. This is not a credible place; this is truly a miracle of technology (Figure 1). Politically, this place is as important as the country's gold mines, major markets or the seat of government.[1] Indeed, the prospect of soaring electricity prices linked to the opaque privatization policies of the Naryn dams were among the grievances that catalysed a popular uprising in Kyrgyzstan in the spring of 2010.

This article investigates the significance of people moving water – and of water moving people – in three distinct and highly significant kinds of places in Kyrgyzstan. These are places that are not usually discussed in the same analytical frame, namely hydroelectric dams, mountain pastures (*jailoo*s) and pilgrimage sites (*mazar*s).[2] *Jailoo*s are a seasonal home to mobile pastoralists and often figure as an (ethnically Kyrgyz) source of wealth, health and beauty. The dam is both a legacy of Soviet ideals and stately powers and a contemporary tool of state regional power. *Mazar*s are holy (*yiyk*) sites of pilgrimage, blessing and healing. Dams are most often discussed in relation to the state and regional water politics, *jailoo*s in terms of economic livelihoods and ecology, and *mazar*s as part of the religious sphere.[3] There is one element of these disparate

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Figure 1. Fellow passenger requesting a picture at Naryn Dam. Photograph by the author.

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types of place that is critical to the quality of each: water. True to its mutable nature, water exerts power in three different ways in each: in the case of the dam it appears first and foremost as a political and economic resource; in the case of *jailoo*s it appears more in the guise of a 'force of nature'; and in the case of *mazar*s its benefits are enspirited.

I contrast these places in order to highlight the role of moving water in each, and to attend to the varied qualities of this movement. While several contributions to this volume explore the infrastructures of people's im/mobility, I focus here on how people conceptualize the im/mobility of a substance, namely water, and how they put these concepts to use. This focus demonstrates that attention to a particular kind of movement of a particular substance can help us to theorize mobility. My analysis is based on participant observation and interviews conducted between 2006 and 2008 in the Toktogul valley of central Kyrgyzstan, in the main with ethnic Kyrgyz, speaking Kyrgyz and Russian. I came to know these places very differently: I lived and worked as a young woman and teacher for 18 months on *jailoo*s and in several villages, visited dams and dam-workers like Bekmurat half a dozen times, and *mazar*s a dozen times. All three places dealt with here are *not* everyday places: they are all outstanding, not entirely mundane. A more detailed discussion would have much more to say about other ways people interact with water, for example through irrigation systems, pumps for drinking water or fountains in town parks.

I investigate here whether ethnographic attention to flowing water in Kyrgyzstan can inform a critique of current metaphors of 'flow' in modelling the world in the social sciences.[4] Creating a dialogue between the ethnographic context of 'flow' depicted here, and the analytical use to which the idea is put in the social sciences shows up the specificity of each. The aim of this critique is not to discard these metaphors as wrong-headed, but simply to note how they silently direct our thought patterns and actions, particularly if they are not recognized as metaphorical. Along with Lakoff and Johnson (1980), I maintain that this is not a banal rhetorical operation, but that these 'metaphors we live by' are likely to influence practice and policy. Noticing these patternings allows us to reflect on their benefits and drawbacks as well as allowing us space to develop alternative ways of describing the world.

I first discuss how Bekmurat and others talk about water and interact with it as a vital substance associated with *tazalyk* (purity, hygiene, uprightness) and certain kinds of water movement. I will then contrast these roles of moving water with its use and potential as hydropower, in the context of Central Asian water politics. In detailing the varying character of water, I discuss how human actors variously regulate and interpret its movement, and how water itself acts as a powerful force shaping human lives.

A world that moves – a world that flows?

That flowing substances, watercourses in particular, have a powerful attraction and positive associations is evident not only from the colloquial imagery of flowing water in Central Asia, but also in colloquial and scholarly English. We may describe the world as consisting of 'streams of information' or the 'flow' of capital, people and goods from one place to another. Central Asia is frequently described as 'flooded' by narcotics or damaged by brain 'drain'. As metaphors-*cum*-theories, this vocabulary makes the social and natural world appear increasingly processual. Scholars from a wide variety of backgrounds have recently engaged in re-describing the world as constituted by movement (Appadurai 1999, Ingold 2000), circulation, connection, networks and flows (Castells 2003, Latour 2005). A fascination with movement is also evident in the many studies of transnationalism and recent classics of anthropology such as Clifford's *Routes* (1997) or philosophy such as Deleuze and Guattari's *Nomadology* (1986).

The focus on – and romance of – movement has also impregnated Central Asia's image: as a network of trading routes between East and West circulating mysteries and luxuries such as Silk (Werner 2003), and as an arena for the mingling of languages, empires, religions and peoples.[5] Currently, such historic movements are generally valued positively, while contemporary mobile things and people tend to be seen as more threatening. In considering these characterizations of areas and eras, is speaking of 'movement' at an abstract level particularly enlightening, or even always a valid category of comparison? Does one not have to specify what kind of thing – rivers, students, currencies – and what kind of movement – sedentarization, visiting kin or commuting to work – one is talking about in order to test whether and how our world is indeed moving? Clearly certain kinds of movements of certain entities are valorized very differently, or not related as forms of movement at all: one obvious example is the huge disparity in regimes for moving capital and people. Certain kinds of movement, such as jet-setting or tourism, are deemed of the 'now' or future, while others such as transhumance appear antiquated. Let me illustrate the value of disaggregating the category 'movement' with a concrete ethnographic example.

When I first started working in Kyrgyzstan, I noticed many ethnic Kyrgyz saying, sometimes proudly, sometimes apologetically, 'we are nomads' (*biz köchmönbüz*). What did people mean by this, I wondered? I speculated whether this expression implied that they found it easier than non-nomads to adapt to new kinds of migrant labour abroad? Many people were surprised when I made such a connection: they had not considered the two phenomena as related in the frame of 'migration' or 'expert movers'. It was evidently not an association with movement as such that people meant by 'we are nomads'. What people meant by 'nomad' seemed rather a particular livelihood, namely mobile livestock breeding, in contrast to growing cereals or trade.[6]

If labour migration and transhumance do not always fit into one interpretive frame, we must ask when and how the umbrella term 'movement' makes sense, and relate it to how people conceive, speak of and practice mundane, joyous and terrifying forms of movement. It is for this reason that I seek to explore specific water 'flows'. I enquire how water, an element that moves of its own accord and yet is considered scarce in Central Asia, is used and understood in central Kyrgyzstan, turning first to water as a feature of *mazar* pilgrimage sites and religious practice.

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Flowing water in the Toktogul valley

The Toktogul valley consists of a wide bowl halfway along the main road between North and South Kyrgyzstan. If one looks at the valley on a map, one sees the dam reservoir spread out at the centre, surrounded by a wide belt of fields, villages and Toktogul town. The Soviet-era Toktogul dam lies sequestered out of sight in a gorge downriver, while the new Kambar Ata dams lie upstream behind the next river bend. The belt of settlements rises toward the surrounding mountains and high pastures. Some *mazar*s are lost beneath the lake now, but the majority lie close to the fringe of villages, rather than the high pastures and sheer peaks beyond, which are only accessible in the summer months. Strikingly, despite the dominance of the reservoir on the map of Toktogul Valley, for most locals the reservoir is not central to the geography of their everyday lives: this large body of water presents rather an absence of usable and accessible space, a periphery used by the odd fisherman (often illegally) and for the occasional bathe. This great mass of water is, by and large, not something engaged with but moved around, on the way to villages on the other side, to Bishkek in the North or Jalalabad in the South. And yet water is part of what makes pilgrimage sites, mountain pastures and, needless to say, the dam itself significant. Relating these disparate yet co-existing places allows us to see how contrasting material conditions – and the ideas, histories and social relations surrounding them – create very different kinds of interactions with water.

In May 2008, I accompanied Talant to see a fortune teller (*közü achyk*) at the most famous *mazar* in the Toktogul Valley: Shamshykal Ata. His wife had kindly invited me to stay with them and learn about the area; she had even made special flat breads for us to offer at the *mazar*. No longer a young man, Talant was nervous about his imminent trip to find work in Moscow: will he make it there? What will it be like? Will he find work easily? Talant tells me people come to Shamshykal Ata, this *taza* (clean, pure, wholesome) place from all over Kyrgyzstan, even Russian people and folk from Tashkent. We set out down the dusty track, towards an oasis of old trees and springs between forbiddingly arid hills, streaked with white seams of valuable salt. Like Talant, pilgrims usually come in humility, seeking comfort from illness and worry. They come to pray, light rush candles, tie a rag to a tree, to sacrifice a goat and take some healing spring water home. A *mazar* has an 'owner' (*ee*), a patron spirit or spirits who may bless pilgrims, but who may also punish disrespectful behaviour such as consuming alcohol at the site. Though no longer prohibited as in the Soviet era, *mazar* visits in Kyrgyzstan tend to be a relatively private affair. Talant and I admire the *mazar*'s miraculous beauty, and he leaves with a lighter heart and some advice from a seer.[7]

Although places can be holy without the presence of good water, healing springs, thermal waters, waterfalls and moist caves are extremely common features of *mazar*s. Prominent examples around Toktogul include Cholpon Ata, where clear spring pools lie alongside a spectacular meeting of rivers and the grave of the 'democrat bard', Toktogul Satylganov.[8] Among a host of smaller *mazar*s there is the 'grandmother spring' *Baibiche Bulak*, which survived attempts by enemies of the Kyrgyz to stop its flow. We often find water at *mazar*s for the prosaic reason that people cannot dwell long where there is no drinking water: visitors like to spend the night at *mazar*s, offer a meal and taste healing waters (Figure 2).

But further, for visitors like Talant, drinking at the Shamshykal Springs is a means of becoming *taza*, clean and healthy in body and soul. Water as a purifying substance that creates *tazalyk* plays an important role in preparing for prayer, Muslim marriage and burial ceremonies, in the blessed water brought back from Mecca, in offering water to guests and receiving blessings in return.[9] The quality of *tazalyk* is also associated with whiteness, like the clothing people like to wear at *mazar*s, or that of Muslim clergy. In the Kazakh context, Privratsky has noted that *tazalyk* is one of the most frequent words used in discussing religion. Islam is often described

Figure 2. Springs at Shamshykal Mazar. Photograph by the author.

as '*taza jol*': the clean path, rather than as in the Koran, the straight path (Privratsky 2001, pp. 79–80). The praise of water and *tazalyk* is also taken up by intellectuals advocating a return to *Kyrgyzchylyk* (or sometimes *Tengirchilik*): what they identify as an ancient Kyrgyz religion and way of life (Köchümkulova 2007, Laruelle 2007).

But there is another type of place that people travel to for *tazalyk*, for health and well-being: summer pastures (*jailoo*s). Upstream from Shamshykal Mazar there is a high mountain valley populated mostly by young families pasturing their livestock in the high summer. I lived here through the summer of 2006 with Anvar, Elmira and their three young children. As we collected dried cowpats for fuel, Elmira remarked wryly: 'This is our life: collecting shit' (*bul bizdin jashoo: biz bok terebiz*). I heard bitterness in her comment and resignation, but we also laughed. I only realized later what a rude word she had used. The herders grumbled at the village council not finding the money to repair the Soviet-built track that would make their pasture moves easier. A herder's lot means living far from modern conveniences such as electricity, shops, roads and health services. Nonetheless, by the end of winter Elmira and Anvar are impatient to move out of their house in the village, eager to set up the *boz üi* (yurt) next to the roaring snowmelt and among thick carpets of purple and orange flowers.

Talking about *jailoo*s brings a light to many people's eyes, whether they are occasional visitors from the city or regular workers in the mountains.[10] Kyrgyz television channels like to show panoramas of such mountain pastures, nodding flowers and thundering streams in the gaps between programmes. Many city apartments are adorned with oil paintings of stylized *jailoo* scenes (Figure 3).

*Jailoo*s are not only beautiful: this is where livestock fatten and where highly valued foods such as the national drink, *kymys*, and a host of other dairy products are produced. Although *jailoo*s are the source of much wealth, this is not what people's comments about *jailoo*s highlight: instead, like Talant describing the *mazar*, mountain pastures are usually characterized as *taza* places of clean air, foods and water. Though this is not often made explicit, there can

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Figure 3. Anonymous painting of a *jailoo* scene in an urban apartment.

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also be the feeling that the *jailoo* is the last refuge of *taza* Kyrgyz customs and proof of the assertion that '*we are nomads*'.

Being at altitude, *jailoo*s are of course close to the glaciers and snowmelt that are the source of most of Kyrgyzstan's watercourses, as yet unpolluted by other human users. But downriver too, there is a noticeable emphasis on watercourses and their purity. Many Kyrgyz place names record the significance and variegated nature of water: villages often carry names such as Ak Suu, Kara Suu, Kyzyl Suu, Jeti Suu (White/Clean Water, Black Water, Red Water, Seven Waters). Water can also feature prominently in funeral laments (singular: *koshok*), comparing the 'force' and goodness of a person to the strength and coolness of rivers and the loss of this person to the loss of water (Köchümkulova 2007, p. 242). Kadyrbek Ata felt responsible for making sure I learnt about the genealogy of the main local patriline, the *sanjyra*. He also made sure I knew how clean and tasty the watercourses around the village were. Their healthy properties had been recorded by scientists and hopefully these qualities would one day be recognized by the World Health Organization.[11] While some people felt responsible for preserving the highly valued cleanliness of the watercourses, others were not so concerned about the effects of washing in the river.[12]

The other aspect that is consistently highlighted in talk of water is its movement. In a mountainous landscape, of course water hardly ever stands still and the sound of running – rushing water even – is never far from any rural human habitation. Nevertheless, it is striking that when water is praised in conversation, in poetry or in proverbs, the emphasis is on movement: the waves of a lake, the gurgle and thunder of streams and rivers, the sparkle and rush of waterfalls. This is the case in many writings by contemporary Toktogul poets, as well as the famous ode *Akkan Suu* (Flowing Water) by Jengijok (Jusupbekov 2006). Considering the general celebration of running water, it is perhaps surprising that unlike rivers such as the Ganges or the Volga, which are celebrated as rivers in their own right, the Naryn does not seem to attract song-writing, or reverence as an entity. Perhaps this is related to the fact that it has not commonly provided direct livelihoods in fishing or river transport in Kyrgyzstan.

I also found clean and running water could be used as a metaphor to talk about history. One of Kadyrbek Ata's relatives, a businessman who had campaigned unsuccessfully in local elections, spoke of their patrilineal descent group (*uruu*), and their power struggles with other village leaders. He explained that their family has strong genes, for after dekulakization it had only taken them two generations to become rich again. He applied the proverb 'water flows in its channels' (*akkan aryktan, suu agat*) to this situation. On another occasion, a historian insisted that the Kyrgyz were a 'polyethnic' (*polietnichnii*) people, that it is necessary to mix blood to avoid 'degeneration'. He said it was like water: blood has to flow, 'otherwise you get stagnant pools'. In these examples, linear, energetic flow is the form and quality of water that is highlighted. Such ways of speaking about generations use the paradox of water streams continuing and recreating themselves through constant change, rivers appearing both as concrete places *and* continuous movement.[13] Flowing water is used here to suggest both a purposefulness to history (natural gravity drawing water in a certain direction) *as well as* the inexorability of change.

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Damming water

If to the people mentioned here the attributes of *tazalyk* and flow are so important in valuing water, how do they feel about the standing water of the valley's huge reservoir? In creating the reservoir, about 35,000 people were displaced from the valley centre in the early 1970s and redistributed along its edges.[14] Although the Toktogul dam reservoir was stocked with fish and planned as a leisure zone in the 1970s, it remains a strangely deserted place, with few settlements on its immediate shore and very little emotional attachment to it on the part of residents (Figure 4). In fact, I heard several people at Shamshykal Mazar worry aloud that since the reservoir had encroached on the site, its precious salts were leaking away. Although to my eyes the reservoir is visually stunning, people like Talant or Elmira never spoke of it enthusiastically, although as we have seen, they extolled other beauty spots and *jailoo*s. The rare lakes of Kyrgyzstan count among the most important sites of beauty; several are at the heart of large nature reserves such as Sary Chelek or Song Köl. But instead of admiring the local reservoir, people extolled the virtues of distant lake Ysyk-köl. If not exactly a *mazar*, this small inland sea surrounded by archaeological remains, holiday resorts and legends is considered holy by many (Abykeev 2009, p. 171). In contrast to Toktogul reservoir, the shore of Ysyk-köl is a hotly contested property market involving investors from Kazakhstan and elsewhere.

One awkward fact about the dam reservoir is that its level rises and falls according to the seasons, and more unpredictably according to international energy prices and demand. This fluctuation creates a bare and clearly artificial drawdown zone on the edge of the reservoir.[15] Though both Ysyk-köl and the reservoir appear as similar blue stretches on maps, and gorgeous landscapes of wide waters and mountains, it seems they take quite a different place in the lives of Toktogul residents. While the Toktogul reservoir is evidence of the sacrifice of land to electricity and modernity, lake Ysyk-köl draws on its natural charms and mythical status to attract very modern tourists to the region. It thus represents a resource, material and spiritual wealth itself, whereas the reservoir is a measure of absence, of all the homes, graves and good land that lie beneath it. The reservoir only becomes 'resource-ful' if transformed into electricity, irrigation or regional power downstream. The habit of ignoring the body of water in their midst also points to the manner of its creation, by displacing people from the land to be flooded. Whereas *tazalyk* and the flow of water are sought out at *mazar*s, *jailoo*s and lakes such as Ysyk-köl, these qualities are not associated with the Toktogul dam reservoir. I now turn to the historical experience of damming the Naryn and the current connections of dam, reservoir and regional politics.

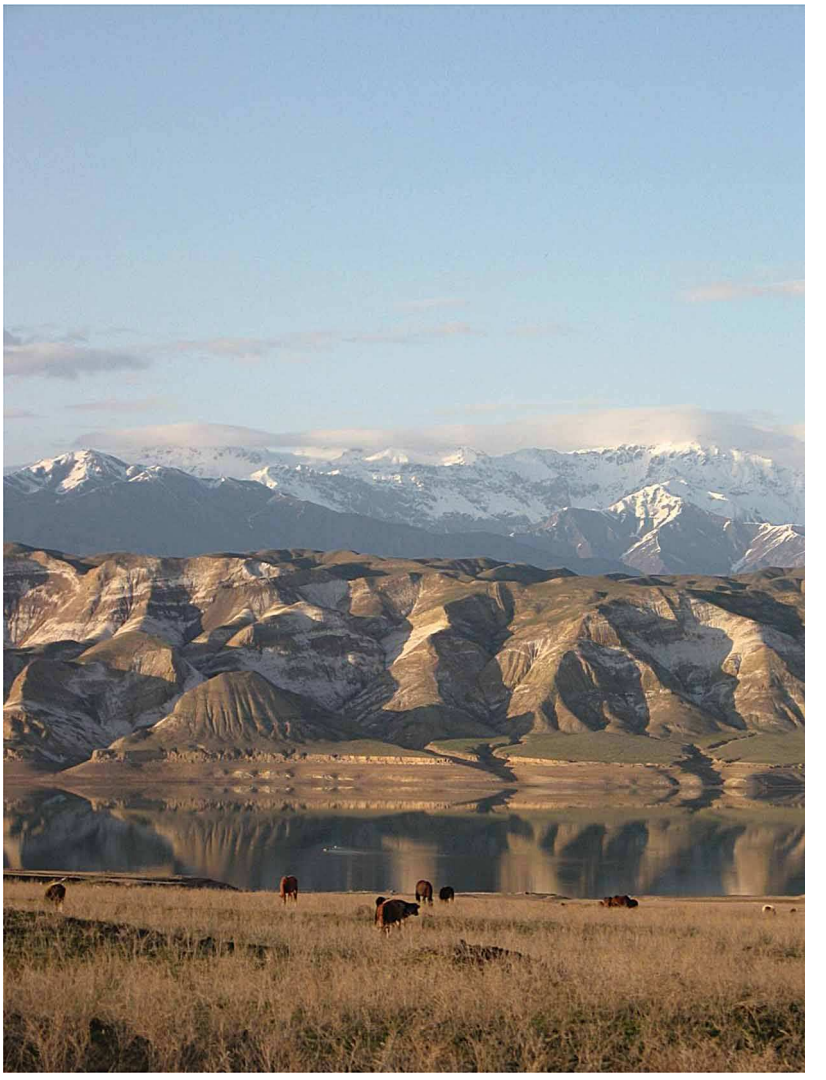

Figure 4. Toktogul reservoir with *mazar* and *jailoo* sites beyond the lake. Photograph by the author.

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If water is widely regarded as a potent, clean substance that can convey blessings and is often depicted as flowing, how is it affected by blocking its flow with a dam and turning it into a source of electricity and regional influence? Water as a problem to be controlled, distributed and fought over is a peculiar resource: its mutability means it can flood, disappear down a hole, evaporate and spill over into other people's states (Baviskar 2007, p. 1). This mutability may make controlling water an even greater source of material and symbolic power than controlling land: controlling water can demonstrate even greater political and technical mastery. But not only do the series of dams on the Naryn temporarily halt and regulate the flow of water, they also generate another mysterious substance: electricity.[16]

Unlike the ethnography suggested here, the scholarly literature of land-locked Central Asia usually concentrates on this aspect of water as a political asset, as a resource whose scarcity is feared to cause conflicts (Bichsel 2009, p. 32).[17] To prevent these, the World Bank and others

advocate privatizing water and governing it through 'water user associations' (Larue 2008).[18] In an area so strongly dependent on irrigation, the saying goes 'better to be the head of the water than the head of the people' (*el bashy bolgucha, suu bashy bol*), that is to say, those upstream or in charge of water, hold the power (Bichsel 2009, pp. 49, 51). If you follow these relations upstream, you encounter the Toktogul dams. If you follow this logic further, you finally come to *jailoo*s.[19]

Water is the trump card that small mountainous countries like Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan can play over more populous and otherwise resource-rich neighbours like Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan and China. As we will see, people in the Toktogul valley may not feel affection for the reservoir waters as they do for their natural rivers and springs, but everyone realizes the political import of their flooded valley. Water 'producing' countries like Kyrgyzstan have often had conflicts of interest over the timing and volume of water released to their downstream neighbours, Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan. While Kyrgyzstan's interest is to release water in the winter to produce electricity, in downriver Uzbekistan this can cause both flooding and a shortage of water for summer crops. Uzbekistan therefore vigorously objects to Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan building further dams, insisting that downriver countries have a say in upriver water management (Sodiqov 2009). The issue here is whether moving waters should be handled like gold, a static commodity sourced in one country, or whether it should be treated as a natural gift, as Uzbekistan insists.[20] Kyrgyzstan meanwhile argues that managing water through the dams is very costly, and demands the financial involvement of downstream countries. The Kyrgyzstani government has achieved such an arrangement with Kazakhstan in the case of the Chü and Talas rivers. Kyrgyzstan's remaining energy supply comes largely from Uzbek-sourced gas, so cases of 'tit for tat' turning off of gas and water supplies are part of the political dispute.

A further factor in the quarrel is that the new Kambar Ata dams are likely to make Kyrgyzstan an energy exporter rather than importer, to make the country independent of Uzbek gas and give it more regional power. Since the Kambar Ata dams are being co-financed by the Russian government, they also give Russia renewed influence in the region. Citizens can gauge not only the seasonal rainfall from the level of the Toktogul Reservoir, but also the level of tensions in regional water disputes. Perhaps it is this politically volatile background (water as source of conflict and 'dirty' deals) that also stops people eulogizing the reservoir, while praising water in the abstract as a dynamic source of life and purity.

When the Toktogul Dam was under construction in the 60s and 70s, slogans celebrating the mastery over nature and forceful domination of the river were hoisted on its concrete walls: *Naryn, serve the people*!' (Russ.: *Naryn*, *sluzhi narodu*!). Like other giant modernist projects such as Magnitogorsk or the infamous Belomor Canal, the dam was an emblem of science altering geography to serve humanity (Kotkin 1997, p. 17).[21] The vocabulary of power reappears in the dam's own turbine hall, which displays a gigantic profile of Lenin as well as his instruction and insight: 'Communism is Soviet power plus the electrification of the whole country.'[21] As I described earlier, the concrete plug of the dam between sheer rocks is indeed awe-inspiring. Its awesome capacity to harness rivers in the name of a better future for humans continues to inspire the poetry of the dam museum's curator (Stefanovich 2007). It also continues to persuade people like Bekmurat to show off the dam rather than the reservoir. Indeed, while films and literature effusively documented the creation of the concrete block that generated electricity, documentation of the changes it wrought in the hinterland was limited to describing the construction of the new town of Toktogul, which replaced the old flooded valley centre.

In the 1970s, villages were created above the reservoir, some of which now depend on electrically driven pumps to supply water. As electricity cuts are frequent, the people who originally moved here for the sake of electricity and water, experience the bitter irony of being left without either. While in the 1970s people did not feel able to resist relocation policies, they now

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complain about a lack of compensation. As an open letter to President Bakiev put it in 2007: 'We were duped into moving from the homes of our ancestors' bones. Who can forget the hidden land?'[23] The reservoir blanketing the valley is not a gain, but a loss of land and *accessible* water. Curiously, the dam that caused these disappearances is invisible from Toktogul valley, lying isolated in a steep-sided gorge. While the access and benefits of pastures and *mazar*s are quite widely distributed, the dam lies out of reach for most citizens, and requires a permit for visitors. Toktogul residents like Talant, Elmira or Kadyrbek Ata have only ever seen the dam – which caused their permanent displacement and fundamentally changed the topography of their homes – on television. While the dam is in some ways truly awesome, the technology employed allows control of its benefits by a small elite of technical specialists and politicians. As the open letter shows, many living close by the dam feel excluded from these benefits. While the clean watercourses and springs of *mazar*s and *jailoo*s are clearly appreciated, the Toktogul reservoir feels much more ambiguous to the people living on its perimeter: it is the source of loss, and celebratory poetry is reserved for the largely inaccessible dam.

This ethnographic discussion of water around Toktogul, the 'clean air and water' mantra about *jailoo*s, the power stored in the dam reservoir, and the healing springs of *mazar*s has revealed water as a vital component in making each of these places awesome. In all the uses and modes of appreciating water discussed here, the fact that it *flows* (whether of its own accord or according to the specifications of dam managers and requirements of the electricity grid) is a central feature. This is true when people extol the literal abundance of pure running water (the higher up the mountain the better) or whether they use water metaphorically to speak of descent and continuity within change. In the case of these metaphors, *taza* holy sites and pastures, water is rarely talked of as disputed, and its benefits for health and happiness are highlighted. Both literally and metaphorically, to the Toktogul residents quoted here, flowing water is a substance that articulates highly desired qualities such as *tazalyk*. However, the value of flow does not always depend on these qualities: the dam derives its importance from the ability to *block* the Naryn's flow, to temporarily halt and exploit it.

We have seen that the Toktogul Dam and Reservoir are two places that can be engaged with separately, namely the concrete dam itself, and the bodies of standing water it creates. Although for a dam to function, the water it channels should preferably have few sediments, whether the water is delicious or poisonous, healthy or not, is of no consequence to dam builders. Dams do not harness the *taza* qualities of water, which is not to say that such ways of valuing water cannot contribute to the dam's aura of power. They depend rather on available volume, on incline and on the political geography up- and downstream.

When water is discussed as a scarce element and object of strife in Central Asia, it appears as a resource capable of generating other resources such as electricity, money, crops and political clout. In this mode of discussion, water appears as a resource to be traded or kept back, hoarded. This way of thinking contrasts starkly with the emphasis on water as a gift with healing powers that *mazar* visitors seek. It is also very far from a river's quality of continuously replacing itself while appearing as one entity, which makes it such an attractive analogy for the passage of time or a claim of continuity between generations.

I turn now to relating the contrasting qualities of water and flow that have emerged in these ethnographic snapshots, with the role of flow in academic descriptions of large-scale social processes. I show that just as the meanings of water highlighted in Toktogul are specific and generated by their use in context, so the description of contemporary life as a matter of 'flow' in academic English has concrete 'sources' and consequences. Juxtaposing these contexts draws out their specificities, and suggests new ways we could talk about movement, globalization or indeed water. I point to several influential descriptions of the social to exemplify the often tacit centrality of flow to current explanations of the world.[24] I show firstly that movement

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appears as a dominant fact currently shaping the world, and secondly that it is identified as 'natural', a characteristic of life itself and consequently, as a good thing. I argue further that movement is frequently equated with 'flow' or sometimes 'flux', and that such 'metaphors we live by' structure attempts to describe the world as well as policies attempting to shape it.

A paradigm of fluidity in the social sciences

Anna Tsing has pointed out that in English, movement connotes the activity of changing place and physical travel, but also of mental and emotional engagement (to be moved) and forms of social and political mobilization (Tsing 2005, p. 213). Certainly there is a tendency to link these meanings; Tim Ingold has argued from a phenomenological perspective that people need to move, in order to 'grasp' the world, to comprehend the world as it unfolds and reveals itself (2000, p. 18). In other words, thinking and understanding necessitates, or perhaps even consists of, a form of movement. The nomad, the *flâneur*, vagabond and tourist – all figures variously associated with 'freedom' – have been adopted as symbols by social theorists from Walter Benjamin to Jean Baudrillard (Urry 2000, pp. 27–29).[25] Deleuze and Guattari see movement as the possibility of change, a freeing up of fixity, and speak of 'nomadic' spaces and groups (Holland 2005, p. 182). Reacting to accounts of the world that focused on static structures, James Clifford recast connections, relations, travel and entanglements as normal rather than exceptional conditions (1989, pp. 3, 7).[26] More recently, Urry has advocated re-organizing sociology around mobilities rather than societies (2000, p. 40). Since attention to change has become paramount among social scientists, the critique of what Malkki describes as a 'sedentarist metaphysic' (1995, p. 16) has become necessary, laudable – and commonplace.[27] Among all the writers mentioned above, one can detect a kind of romance of mobility, its association with life and an association of stasis with death (Kirby 2009, p. 15). Movement appears as: (1) the stuff of life itself; (2) a pre-requisite for thought and action; and (3) particularly typical of this day and age. It has become a dominant descriptor of the world, and a highly valued characteristic associated with independence, thought and freedom. As Reeves points out in her introduction to this volume, spatial tropes can be politically persuasive. The sense that movement *per se* is a good can be traced in areas as various as international financial markets, travel as a booming leisure pursuit or the depiction of 'free' Inner Asian nomads.[28] Recognizing this, Tsing has warned of a new 'Orientalism' of false dichotomies that portrays moving people as the positive norm in contrast to the 'stagnant' rest (Tsing 2000, p. 346). That a commitment to mutability and impermanence is also a pre-requisite to consumer capitalism might make us careful about the conflation of these images and values, the celebration of 'flux'.

Even a writer such as Urry, who is explicit about looking at the metaphors of movement employed in examining globalization, on occasion switches from talking about movement to 'flow' without comment. 'Flow' is usually linked to the idea of circulation, particularly of money and information: money as water or life-blood that should be encouraged to circulate as freely as possible (Tsing 2000, p. 336).[29] Castells goes so far as to see flows as a new kind of spatial logic to the old one of places (2003, p. 433). David Harvey put it thus: 'The state is a territorial entity struggling to impose its will upon a fluid and spatially open process of capital circulation' (Harvey 1990, p. 108). As in Harvey's quotation, such flows are often opposed to the nation-state, conceived as a solid structure or container.[30] It is striking that money, commodities, information and people can all so easily be talked about as if they behaved like fluids. The word 'flow' seems to do a lot of work, being evocative and visceral enough to capture the reader, abstract and dynamic enough to easily transfer to other contexts. The notion of 'flow' can appeal to the free marketeer, the phenomenologically grounded thinker, the fashion-conscious organic designer or to those drawn to Eastern martial arts.

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Re-describing the world as moving is often explicitly presented as an antidote to ills such as ethnic chauvinism and the over-exploitation of natural resources linked to ideas and practices that divide things and people. A fluid world of mobility and mutability promises a conceptual and practical binding together of humanity, even if the binding together is not on an equal footing. Several authors have critiqued the prevalence of 'flow speak' as promoting the mirage of a boundless and disembodied world, occluding the central role of consumption as creating 'flows' and the way these are actively channelled (Tsing 2005, p. 337, Bude and Dürrschmidt 2010, p. 483). Tsing's emphasis on friction as *enabling* motion, both literally and metaphorically, is an important counterpoint to the general enthusiasm for moving and flow. She speaks of global connections as 'zones of awkward engagement, where words mean something different across a divide even as people agree to speak' (2005, p. xi). The language of 'flow' and water may itself be the kind of 'zone of awkward engagement' Tsing describes. In Central Asia, the term 'flow' is not so easily applied to negatively connoted movements such as drug smuggling or refugees.

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Conclusion: an ethnography of water as critique of academic language

Along with Tsing, I contend that metaphors of a world of 'fluids', 'flow', 'drainage' and so on are based on the behaviour of water rather than honey and lava, for instance. The movements of water (and sometimes blood), so central to human life, lend themselves to a great breadth of metaphorical uses. This breadth is evident in the difference between the characteristics of 'flow' that English-language social scientists currently engage with, and what Toktogul residents highlighted as important about the flow of water. Let me summarize which aspects of water are highlighted by these different constituencies and how water metaphors are put to use.

A commonality can be detected in the focus on flow as a particular rhythm and process: a relatively continuous, detectable passage over a long time. Appadurai provides one example of such ideas of watery flow: 'Where once improvisation was snatched out of the glacial undertow of habitus, habitus now has to be painstakingly reinforced in the face of life-worlds that are frequently in flux' (Appadurai 1999, p. 472). In conceptualizing physical and temporal movements, like the businessman describing his family's fortunes as 'flowing in its channels', social scientists may invoke this positive, non-threatening (not flood, not drought) quality. Both the examples from Toktogul and from the social sciences emphasize the 'naturalness' of flow, the draw of gravity and linearity. One might also note that in neither domain is the *transparency* of water picked out as particularly relevant. Images of an unproblematic merging of streams to a larger watercourse and the fluidity of borders are common when social commentators and policy makers speak of migration or commerce. This aspect of flows is also emphasized by the Kyrgyz historian fearing 'stagnant pools' of unmixed people. If people widely imagine flow to be necessary to life itself, then channelling and corralling a running river with a dam is both an eerie and a particularly powerful thing to do. Along with the very real losses suffered by Toktogul residents in order to make this possible, this 'stagnation' may be a reason why people living on its rim do not dwell easily on the reservoir.

Just as I suggested that the concept of movement is worth differentiating, so examples of how different qualities of water and its movements are highlighted demonstrate that 'flow' can connote different things. I have demonstrated that although everyone mentioned in this article gives water and its movement positive meanings, to Toktogul thinkers, such 'flow' implies different things to the English commentators cited here. What if the Toktogul residents were to focus on flow as *circulation*, as Castells or Appadurai do? Conversely, what if social scientists were to invoke qualities such as *tazalyk* to describe processes of moving money, ideas or electricity? Rather than offering a definitive and circumscribed meaning, the imagery of flow, based

on the experience of flowing water escapes these kind of manoeuvres, retaining a fluidity both productive and appealing to a romantic notion of movement.[31]

This article set out to demonstrate that it is worth paying attention to a particular kind of movement and substance, namely flow and water, in thinking about mobility. Ethnographic snapshots of *mazar*s and *jailoo*s, dam walls and lakes reveal some core themes and discrepancies in how Kyrgyz citizens might think about water and use it. But these snapshots and ways of speaking also show up what they have in common with thinkers in the social sciences (emphasis on flow as continuity within change, naturalness) and highlighting what is specific about 'flow talk' in each domain (valuing *tazalyk* on the one hand, circulation on the other). Clearly, the image of water and flow employed around Toktogul and in the pages of social science articles do not map neatly onto each other. One further question this article throws up is whether and how connotations from one sphere of life, circle of people and communication become relevant to decisions made in another. How far might the fashion for thinking through 'flow' have implications for the politics of water worldwide and the building of new dams in Central Asia? Listening in to the flow-speak at the next round of regional water governance talks might prove instructive.

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Notes

1. I concentrate here on the Toktogul Dam, the spectacular head in a cascade of dams on the Naryn River, leading towards the Ferghana Valley. The new Kambar Ata dam projects are based on a Soviet plan to continue damming the Naryn upstream. As a way out of energy shortages and regional dependencies, these plans were revived in 2007 and funded by the Kyrgyz state and foreign (mainly Russian) investors. The political and environmental complexities of these dams as well as summer pastures and *mazar*s are treated more fully elsewhere (Féaux de la Croix 2010a, 2010b).
2. I use the word *jailoo* here to refer to all pastures that people migrate to, that is, spring, summer and autumn pastures, but not those closest to the village. Although there are more specific terms for these different kinds of pastures, they can be collectively referred to as *jailoo* in everyday speech.
3. See Weinthal (2002), O'Hara (2003), Marat (2008) and Sehring (2009) on dams and water in such contexts. On pastures see Sitianskii (1998), Bunn (2000), Jacquesson (2003), Kerven (2003) and Schmidt (2006). On *mazar*s as part of popular religion see Abramzon (1971), Tyson (1997), Aitpaeva (2007) and Louw (2007).
4. Although there is no space here to draw a broader comparison of different kinds of human movements associated with these places such as forceful displacement, pilgrimage or transhumance, the reader will find a number of articles in this issue commenting on these associations (see particularly Kassymbekova, Dubuisson and Genina, Isabaeva and Reeves, this volume).
5. Other examples of areas that are associated with the idea of movement rather than staying power are the American West or the Indian Ocean. Interestingly, like Central Asia, these areas are not predominantly seen as generating movement, but receiving or 'hosting' it: empires come to them, rather than vice versa.
6. This despite *köchmön* deriving from the verb 'to move' (see Bunn, this volume). The fact that entire 'mentalities' are derived from historic livelihoods and presented as opposing, rather than complimentary or mixed, has played an unhappy role in the recent violence in the south of Kyrgyzstan.
7. It should be noted that these *mazar* visits do not confer the kind of status of the *hajj* to Mecca: this is again a case where the English category – 'pilgrimage' – encompasses phenomena that are differentiated by actors.

8. Toktogul Satylganov (1864–1933) is the celebrated 'democrat bard' after which the valley and district centre are now named.
9. Strang has suggested that because we ingest water, expulse it and can be immersed in it, such strong ideas of pollution and cleanliness in relation to water are very widespread (2004, p. 5). Certainly holy wells and springs are common in many areas of the world such as northern Europe.
10. I am not claiming universal adoration of the pastoral lifestyle: for many, pastures are inaccessible because they lack livestock and tent or yurt to sustain them there, or find it difficult to assert their right to grazing among other users. Others find *jailoo*s boring, or resent the hard manual work life there requires. A fuller discussion of the economic and symbolic significance of *jailoo*s can be found in Féaux de la Croix (2010b).
11. The question of why the Toktogul area is so rich in musicians could be answered in many ways, one being that it was because of the purity of the local water, which is 'like gold'.
12. Interestingly, in the Kyrgyz–Tajik border areas, whether it is acceptable to wash clothes or dishes in canals is identified as an important marker of ethnic difference (pers. comm. Madeleine Reeves, 5 April 2010). Whether or not people care particularly about keeping water courses clean, outside *mazar*s I never heard fears that polluting water might anger its spirit (*ee*) and bring misfortune, as people might worry in other areas such as Tuva (Humphrey and Sneath 1996, pp. 12–13).
13. Raffles has pointed out how rivers, like the railroad tracks invoked by Latour, are 'local at all points' (Latour 1993, p. 117), and thus transgress the conventions of human space (Raffles 2007, p. 315).
14. It has been noted elsewhere that Soviet citizens were subject to a distinctive regime of mobility that forced some people, such as collective farm workers to stay in place, while others experienced redefinition, mass exodus and subsequent famine. These resettlements had the dual aim of facilitating progress, and facilitating control of citizens (Kotkin 1997, Schoeberlein 2000, Brown 2004, Uehling 2004).
15. This drawdown zone is also disliked by locals on the Kemi dams in Finland and cited as one reason why they do not think of reservoirs as lakes (pers. comm. Franz Krause, 16 November 2010).
16. Note that water is a commonly used analogy to explain the behaviour of electricity, and that in both domains the terms 'flow' and 'current' are used.
17. This scarcity is a global phenomenon provoked by an enormous increase in population as well as water 'needs', such as new norms of hygiene and agriculture (Baviskar 2007, p. 2).
18. See O'Hara (2003), Larue (2008), Bichsel (2009) and Sehring (2009).
19. Massive plans to reverse Siberian rivers to water Central Asia have been discussed since the nineteenth century, most recently revived by Kazakh President Nazarbayev after the catastrophic droughts in Russia and Western Kazakhstan (Central Asia–Caucasus Analyst 2010).
20. In the short term, while the new reservoir fills up, there will certainly be a shortfall of water or electricity somewhere that will require careful management.
21. Many enormous dams were built in the post-war period, not only under Socialist governments. What official discourses around Socialist dams emphasized more than say, the Hoover Dam, is the zeal of the dam workers, and the spirit of international friendship driving the work.
22. *'Kommunizm eto sovetskaia vlast' plius elektrifikatsiia vsei strany'* (Lenin 1920).
23. Open letter to President Bakiev, *Shamshykal* newspaper, 25 May (Akmataliev 2007).
24. Though I cannot claim a representative sample of any kind here, I have chosen authors from different fields to show that the conceit of movement and flow have a wide appeal across disciplines and topics.
25. Although much more could be said on Deleuze and Guattari's treatment of actual nomadic history or the nomad figure, this would require another article.
26. Note that here we have already moved from talking about 'movement' in general to 'travel', implying some distance and duration.
27. Fabian (1983, p. 29) has pointed out how time and space often serve as metaphors for each other, 'far away' being equated with 'long ago', while others claim that through recent 'time-space compression' (Harvey 1990), speeding up communications and travel, some of us now live in a 'global village' (McLuhan 1962). This is particularly relevant for modernist projects like socialism, which conceived political programmes of change as a 'road' to Communism, to a better future.
28. See also Dubuisson and Genina (this volume).
29. For example, Castells defines flows as 'purpose-oriented, repetitive, programmed sequences of exchange and interaction' (author's translation from Castells 2003, p. 467).
30. Similar formulations can be found in Appadurai (1999, p. 5).
31. Note however that this is not an *unpredictable* kind of fluidity.

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